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KINSHIP AND CULTURE: SOME PROBLEMS IN NDEMBU KINSHIP¹

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INTRODUCTION

THE PURPOSE OF THIS PAPER is to analyze several aspects of Ndembu kinship concerning descent, filiation, and affinity as parts of a symbolic system. As the work of Lévi-Strauss (1949) has indicated, kinship systems have an ideological aspect which must be analyzed in its own terms, apart from social structural considerations. The categories, concepts, and logical interrelations of such an ideology are summarized in symbolic form. We will examine some Ndembu kinship symbols, analyze the relations between them, and attempt to state these relationships in a parsimonious but enlightening model.

We will propose that some parts of the ideological dimension of Ndembu kinship can be handled differently from V. W. Turner's analysis (Turner 1957) and that they can be neatly described by a model of double unilineal descent and a four section marriage system.

THE NDEMBU

The Ndembu are cultivators and hunters in the northwestern corner of Zambia in Central Africa. They raise cassava—their staple crop, maize, millet, beans, and sweet potatoes (Turner 1957:20). The gardens in which these crops are raised are owned and worked individually, the men doing the heaviest work, the women the hoeing, cultivating, harvesting, and cooking (pp. 22-24).² But in Ndembu terms, men are primarily hunters. Hunting is surrounded by an elaborate ritual, which shows the overwhelming importance of this subsistence pursuit in Ndembu values (pp. 25ff.). Men engage in what little collective work or collective consumption is done (p. 33).

Women practice virilocal residence after marriage; adult men tend to live avunculocally; children therefore reside patrilocally. A village is thought to be composed of a headman and people who are linked to him by various kinds of ties of consanguinity and affinity. The marriage tie is fragile. Women who are divorced, widowed, or past the menopause return to live with their own matrilineal kin (pp. 61-63).

Succession to village headmanships and to chiefships is matrilineal (p. 82).

1 I wish to thank Dr. V. W. Turner for reading and commenting on an earlier draft of this paper.

2 Page references are to Turner 1957, except where other sources are cited.

The offices pass between male matrilineal kin of one generation until there are no more eligible men in that generation, and then to the man who is the most senior member of the next lower generation. Similarly, inheritance is matrilineal (p. 82). At a man's death, a matrilineal kinsman is appointed executor, and he distributes the property to matrilineal kin after the dead man's share of the year's crops has been used to feed people at the funeral ceremonies. A man's widow and children receive a share only at the will of the matrilineal kinsmen. Status is inherited matrilineally as well (p. 87): a slave wife of a free man and her children remain slaves at the death of the husband and father. They are inherited by his heirs.

DESCENT AND FILIATION

The Ndembu have an ideology of matrilineal descent. One of the most obvious ways this ideology is expressed is in the use of the term *ivumu*, the "womb." Ndembu consider their society to be divided into segmented lineages composed of people related through women to a common ancestress. Segments of lineages are divided according to the sibling order of birth of their respective apical ancestresses. Senior lineages are *ivumu damukulumpi* (-*mukulumpi* = "elder"); junior lineages are *ivumu dakansi* (-*kansi* = "child").

The idea of matrilineal descent is further expressed in a folktale which relates how, when a village is in danger, a man attempts to save his hunting gear, and a woman to save her child (pp. 27,28). The woman's matrilineal kinsmen rebuke the man for valuing hunting more highly than the child. These values are expressed in a Ndembu saying: "For the man, huntsmanship; for the woman, procreation." There are some further implications of the womb symbol, *ivumu*, in this ideology. When a woman is about to bear her first child, she will go to her matrilineal village for her confinement. A ceremony will be performed there, *ku-tena ivumu*, "the mentioning of the womb" (pp. 54,55). After the ceremony she may return to her husband's village for the birth; or she may remain in her own village and return to her husband's village after the birth. At the birth of a first child, the father will also give a goat to the headman of his wife's matrilineage (p. 132).

These events surrounding the birth of a first child give expression to two aspects of Ndembu descent ideology. The first is the symbolic significance of what may be called "the first instance." The confinement ceremony and the gift-giving are performed only for the first child. That this symbolism of "the first instance" seems to run through much of Ndembu symbolism was confirmed by Turner (1965), who suggests that it may be related to the fact that alliances

between Ndembu, be they marriages or blood brotherhood or village political alliances, are extremely fragile. He is impressed by the great mobility of the Ndembu and the transitory character of so many of their social relationships. But on the other hand, this observation probably does not exhaust the symbolic importance of these performances of the "first instance." They could, in fact, point to some kinds of more "enduring" conceptual relationships which are implicit in Ndembu social thought.

As a second aspect of descent ideology, Ndembu beliefs concerning birth are reflected in the symbols which express the relationship between mother and child. Ndembu refer to a woman's role in conception and birth as that of a container, a calabash, for the child. In Ndembu ideas of anatomy, the stomach and the womb are not clearly distinguished. Both are regarded as containers, and they both may be referred to as having a role in pregnancy (Turner 1965). Women, in general, are likened to the gourd-like fruit of a calabash plant which has many seeds inside. This also provides the image of the matrilineage, comprising a woman and her descendants (Turner 1965). Other symbols concerning pregnancy indicate that the mother is thought to provide nourishment and blood to the child (Turner 1965).

The contribution of the father in the conception of a child contrasts to the mother's role. The father contributes the "seed of life," and he may be responsible for the child's bone (Turner 1965). He is, at any rate, associated with whiteness, which elsewhere in Ndembu symbolism expresses goodness and the absence of evil, witchcraft, or sorcery. Women, on the other hand, are associated with the red of the blood of menstruation and parturition. Red is the color of evil.

The symbolic opposition between the role of father and of mother in birth and conception expresses something more than sex role differentiation. They, as well as other symbols, distinguish a person's relationship to his father from that to his mother's brother. Not only can a person inherit only from his mother's brother, and not from his father, but a mother's brother can sell a sister's child into slavery. A father cannot in this manner dispose of his own child. He is, in fact, thought to be his child's protector (p. 189). Further, accusations of sorcery may be made between a mother's brother and sister's son. The bone of contention is succession to headmanships, the jealousy over which is symbolized by the snake familiar, *ilomba* (p. 122).

The symbolism of blood further differentiates uterine siblings from siblings who have only a father in common. Uterine siblings regard themselves as full (*chikupu*) siblings regardless of their fathers (p. 67). One's blood kin are one's natural supporters: in village politics the basic unit is a man and his fertile

siblings (p. 231). One's rights of residence follow the same pattern. A person may reside permanently in the village of his matrilineal kin, but in the village of his father only during the latter's lifetime (p. 64).

There may be two different kinds of distinctions between a person's relationships to his mother, on the one hand, and to his father, on the other. It seems that a person is related by birth (filiation) to both mother and father, as symbolized in Ndembu beliefs about biology and about residence rights. But, in addition, one has a distinctive relationship to mother and mother's brother, namely, co-membership in a descent unit. This relationship is expressed in all the symbols of matrilineal descent we have just discussed: 1) rights in inheritance, succession, status, residence, etc., and 2) the symbols of blood and the womb.

In the Ndembu case thus far, we have found not one opposition, but two. The first has to do with filiation: the roles of father and mother are opposed symbolically as producing bone or blood and as representing the seeds of life or the container for the child. The second has to do with descent unit membership. Here the opposition is mother and mother's brother (who are one's co-members in a descent unit) as against father, a non-member.

This hypothesis is supported by what the Ndembu consider to be incestuous relationships. Turner states that although incest prohibitions apply to only a relatively narrow range of kin (p. 86), marriages are forbidden between members of "effective local lineages" because such marriages would be incestuous (*chimal-wamalwa* or *chipikapika*) (p. 196). It would appear at first that the conceptual units of Ndembu society are exogamous matrilineages having a depth of about four generations. A ritual, *ku-sola* or *ku-disola*, to cleanse the guilt of incest is required if a man and woman have a common great-grandmother (p. 196). Further, the only exclusively lineage ritual, according to Turner, is *kuswanika ijina*, which consists of planting a *muyomba* tree in the village to a matrilineal ancestor or ancestress and giving that ancestor's name to a village member (p. 195). This ritual involves people who are within the four-generation span.

But the correspondence between matrilineal segments and incest prohibitions is not neat. It is, therefore, necessary to sort out terminological categories of kin from specific kinsmen who may be included in a particular category. Of the category of people called *ankaka* (grandparents; sing. *nkaka*) and *ejikulu* (grandchildren; sing. *mwijikulu*), some kinsmen are proscribed marriage partners, among them a male Ego's own MoMo and FaMo; a marriage of this kind would be *kushimena*, "unnatural" (Turner 1965). At the same time, a man can marry his own SiDaDa, a very close lineal relative. This latter preference raises the question whether a kinsman in a matrilineal society can be both a consanguine

and an affine at the same time. This would clearly be a contradiction to Leach's hypothesis (1961:20) that in a unilineal descent system a child will have a relationship of descent, and therefore consanguinity, with one parent and the opposite one, that of affinity, with the other. The solution, we believe, lies in separating symbolic domains. This problem will be developed later.

KINSHIP TERMINOLOGY

We turn first to the analysis of another set of symbols—Ndembu kinship terminology. Ndembu kinship terminology (see Fig. 1) is of the Iroquois type, in which the following equations (for a male Ego) are found:

- 1) $Fa = FaBr = MoSiHu \neq MoBr$
- 2) $Mo = MoSi = FaBrWi \neq FaSi$
- 3) $Sibl = ParCous \neq CrCous$
- 4) $Ch \neq SiCh$

From Lévi-Strauss (1949;1965) we believe that we have reason to look for evidence of a system of exchange in a set of kinship symbols. By "a system of exchange" we mean that principle of solidarity which is expressed by the circulation of goods between social segments. These "goods" may be women, for marriage is the most important kind of exchange. On the other hand, the "goods" may be pigs or gongs. Pigs and gongs are symbols which, in such a case, reiterate the more important exchange of sisters for wives. We also have reason to suspect that an exchange system may be expressed in the symbols of kinship terminology. We will begin there.

Dumont (1957:25,26) has analyzed the structure of the kinship terminology of some south Indian groups. This analysis is applicable to the Ndembu terminology, for the Ndembu have an ideology of bilateral cross-cousin marriage. The resulting structure is quite similar to the Indian cases. The point that Dumont makes is that in societies in which there is a positive marriage rule³

1) marriage should be considered as part of a marriage alliance institution running through generations; 2) the concept of affinity should be extended so as to include not only immediate, individual relationships (affines in the ordinary sense) but also the people who inherit such a relationship from their parents, those who share it

3 A "positive marriage rule" is the structural principle of exchange of women between social units, which may be reiterated by other sorts of goods, e.g., pigs or gongs.

The Ndembu ideology of bilateral cross-cousin marriage is preferential "at the level of reality," but it is prescriptive "at the level of the model" (see Lévi-Strauss 1965:17). On the level of the model the Ndembu have a positive marriage rule, which is symbolically marked by their statements about their preference of marriage with the bilateral cross-cousin.

as siblings of the individual affines, etc.; 3) there is likely to be an affinal content in terms which are generally considered to connote consanguinity or "genealogical" relationships (such as "mother's brother," etc.) (Dumont 1957:25).

nkaka GrFa		
tata Fa	[=♂]	mandumi MoBr
yaya, mwamyika Br	[=♂]	musonyi CrCous
mwana So	[=♂]	mwiha SiSo
mwijikulu GrSo		

Key

[=♂] = affinal tie

FIG. 2. Male kin.

As with Dumont's south Indian groups, in the Ndembu terminology the two sexes can be analyzed separately. Then, in GrFa's and GrSo's generations there is one term for all males; in the intermediate generations there is a dichotomy between Fa and MoBr, between Br and CrCous, and between own So and SiSo. The same occurs in terms for female kin (see Figs. 2 and 3).

That is, Ndembu kin are terminologically distinguished 1) by sex, 2) by generation, and 3) by a third principle, which divides Ndembu society "verti-

cally" into two opposing segments. The relationship between these two segments is very likely that of affinity, for it represents two social segments related by the exchange of women between them.

nkaka GrMo		
mama Mo	[=Δ]	tata wamumbanda FaSi
muheka Si	[=Δ]	musonyi CrCous
mwana Da	[=Δ]	mwiha SiDa
mwijikulu GrDa		

Key

[=Δ] = affinal tie

FIG. 3. Female kin.

There are two sources of evidence which support this hypothesis. First, the term for FaSiHu is *mandumi*, the term for MoBr (McCulloch 1951:20). However, too much weight should not be attached to this overlapping reference, for Turner says that he was unable to confirm this in the field (Turner 1966). But a second source of evidence is the Ndembu ideology concerning bilateral cross-cousin marriage.

Cross-cousinship, like the grandparent-grandchild relationship, is a joking partnership. Perhaps on account of the egalitarian nature of the tie between cross-cousins in Ndembu society, the joking is of a more boisterous type than that between kin belonging to alternate generations. It is symmetrical, sexual in content, derogatory in manner, and often contains reference to the sorcery or witchcraft of the joking partner. Cross-cousins make free with one another's possessions, those of opposite sex indulge in sexual play, and cross-cousin marriage is the preferred form of marriage. Ndembu men appear to marry their patrilateral and matrilineal cross-cousins with equal frequency (Turner 1957:253-254).

What bilateral cross-cousin marriage amounts to conceptually is the exchange of sisters for wives between two social segments. Bilateral cross-cousin marriage fits

TABLE 1
Terminological Contrast between Allied Generations

adjacent generations	aku
own and alternate generations	nkaka, mwijikulu

a model of direct exchange, or a social world divided into two parts—"we" and "they." Any social unit may give wives, or goods, to any other unit and, in turn, receive wives and goods from any other unit.

CONSANGUINEALS AND AFFINES

But the Ndembu case is not one of simple direct exchange. There are two principles which make the matter more complex: 1) the alliance of alternate generations, and 2) the distinction between relatives by birth and by marriage.

The alliance between alternate generations is concretely expressed in the arrangement of huts in a village. Members of allied generations build huts together on one half of a circle; members of the adjacent, opposed generations on the other half (p. 240). But although each of the terms for grandparents, *ankaka*, and for grandchildren, *ejikulu*, merges the respective generations with regard to sex and relative age, there is no term which includes both alternate generations. On the other hand, the opposed set of adjacent generations are collectively referred to as *aku* (p. 240). This term is reciprocal (see Table 1).

According to Turner, *aku* are respected, feared, and avoided (p. 240). Ego makes a distinction between *aku* in his behavior toward them. *Aku* who are

senior in generation to Ego command respect and fear, for they are in authority over him. Junior *aku* show respect for Ego and his generation. Another symbol which expresses this respect and avoidance relationship between *aku* is conflict between generations over succession to headmanships, which is symbolized by *ilomba*, the snake familiar mentioned above.

Marriages can take place between members of allied generations. Ego can marry a woman who is *nkaka* or *mwijikulu*, although some specific kinsmen to whom these terms apply are prohibited. Turner says that the Ndembu consider *ankaka* and *ejikulu* to be similar to *ansonyi*, cross-cousins, rather than to siblings

TABLE 2
Generational Alliances and Marriage Rules

adjacent generations	aku	
	yaya, mwanyika, muhela	nkaka, mwijikulu, musonyi
own and alternate generations	prohibited marriage	preferred marriage

(p. 80). The relationship is a joking one, but between grandparents and grandchildren it is slightly different from that between cross-cousins. In the latter case, joking is reciprocal; but in the former case, joking seems to be directed mostly from *ankaka* (GrPa) toward *ejikulu* (GrCh). *Ejikulu* must show the respect to *ankaka* which is due senior people. (*Ankaka* is also the word for owners of slaves [p. 183].)

On the other hand, the relationship between *ankaka*, *ejikulu*, or *ansonyi* contrasts to that between *aku* or siblings (*yaya*, *mwanyika*, and *muhela*) in sexual matters. *Ankaka* (GrPa) instruct *ejikulu* (GrCh) in sexual mores and techniques. There is sexual joking between *ankaka*, *ejikulu*, and *ansonyi*, but none with *aku*. The sexual restraint between siblings is expressed in sorcery accusations against a man who sits on his sister's mat (p. 252). The conceptual division according to generational alliance and marriage preferences and proscriptions are represented in Table 2.

A narrower meaning of *aku* is "inlaws of an adjacent genealogical generation" (p. 235). This narrower meaning of *aku* is used to refer to MoBr and

FaSi (p. 235). It contrasts with *mashaku*, which Turner glosses "inlaws of one's own genealogical generation" (p. 235). It seems reasonable to suspect that the term might also denote the alternate generations with which one's own generation is allied. Turner confirms this to be the case (Turner 1966). *Mashaku*, then, is used to refer to *ankaka*, *ejikulu*, and *ansonyi*. *Aku* and *mashaku* together are *wusoku wakusumbwang'ana*, kinsmen by marriage, which contrasts with *wusoku wakuvwalika*, or *awusoku*, kinsmen by birth. Both these categories are subsumed into the category *awusoku*, which denotes "kinsmen or inlaws" (p. 235). These are diagrammed in Table 3.

TABLE 3
Contrasts between Kinsmen by Birth or Marriage and between Allied Generations

awusoku	
wusoku wakuvwalika (kinsmen by birth)	wusoku wakusumbwang'ana (kinsmen by marriage)
awusoku	aku
	mashaku

DIRECT EXCHANGE AND ALLIANCE OF ALTERNATE GENERATIONS

The interrelationships will now be examined between Ndembu ideas of descent and filiation, consanguinity and affinity, direct exchange and alliance of alternate generations. Logically, the intersection of the two principles—direct exchange and alliance of alternate generations—suggests some kind of marriage section system. It is possible to demonstrate how the section system may be derived from direct exchange and alliance of alternate generations.

Direct exchange in this case is the exchange of sisters for wives between social units. It suggests that the social world is conceptually divided into two opposite categories: kinsmen and affines. Any social unit may give wives to many different units and, in turn, receive wives from the same, or other, units; there is no distinction between wife-givers and wife-receivers. To segment A, B is simply the category of "affines," which includes both wife-givers and wife-receivers.

But the Ndembu add another principle: the exchange of sisters for wives is limited to alternate generations. The giving and receiving of wives between ad-

jacent generations is prohibited. The model now logically has four parts (see Fig. 4). If the Ndembu ideology of matrilineal descent is the contrasting feature between the two social segments in the model, the model becomes one composed of matrilineally related sibling units which exchange women (see Table 4).

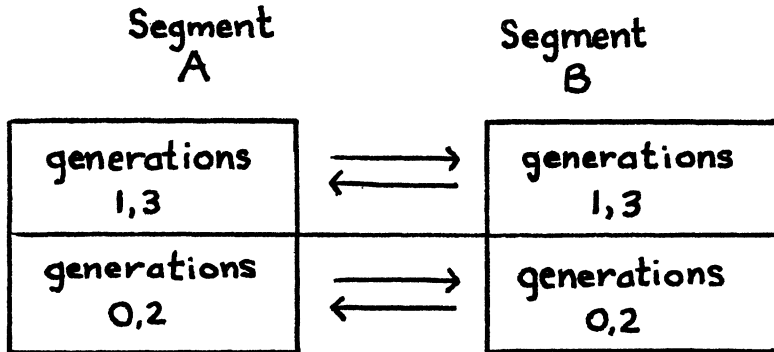


FIG. 4. Model of restricted direct exchange.

This interpretation is supported by what we have seen to be the symbols of matrilineal descent. Mother and mother's brother are related to Ego by blood; inheritance, succession, and status are matrilineal; some special kinds of familiars

TABLE 4
Contrasts in Ndembu Terminology by Descent and Generation

	Own Matrilineal Descent Unit	Affines
adjacent generations	mandumi mama mwiha	tata tata wamumbanda mwana
own and alternate generations	yaya mwanyika muhela	nkaka musonyi mwijikulu

and illnesses plague matrilineal kin. But there is also evidence that appears to contradict this interpretation. First of all, there is the problem presented by *nkaka* and *mwijikulu*. We would expect that some kin types included in these

categories, namely MoMo or SiDaDa (for male Ego) and FaFa, MoMoBr, or BrSoSo (for female Ego), are co-members of a descent unit and therefore are prohibited marriage partners. But we have already seen that the Ndembu prohibit marriage with MoMo and FaMo but that marriage between MoMoBr and SiDaDa is positively valued. In one sense, all these kin types are members of the same descent unit. But, on the other hand, in another symbolic domain *ankaka* (GrPa) and *ejikulu* (GrCh), including the kin types just mentioned are affines, *mashaku* (see Table 3). In the terms of these symbolic domains, specific kin types cannot be sorted out and assigned absolutely to either the category of consanguineals or that of affines. Such assignments can be made only with reference to one symbolic domain or the other.

Related to this is another problem. The set of *awusoku* distinctions express Ndembu notions of filiation and affinity. But both kin types and kin terms can be assigned to either the category of consanguineals or to that of affines only when the particular symbolic domain is known. A MoBr, then, is either a consanguineal, as MoBr, or an affine, as WiFa, depending upon the domain referred to.

One further question is raised, namely, the possibility of a principle of double unilineal descent. The four section system was the result of the intersection of the principles of direct exchange between social segments and the alliance of alternate generations. In Ndembu kinship and marriage these principles are expressed in the exchange of women between sibling units as well as the prohibition of marriage between adjacent generations and the preference for marriage between alternate generations.

Let us now examine the differences in paternal origins of each section, in terms of the patrilineal units which cross-cut the matrilineal descent units. We will take an example from the sections in Fig. 4. For a male Ego in category A(0,2), Mo will be A(1,3) and Fa will be B(1,3). Ego's children will be B(1,3), whereas SiCh will be A(1,3). At the same time that a person's place in the system is determined by his Mo's place, that is, by matrilineal descent and by generation, it is also determined by his Fa's place. A male Ego's children will be in the category of Ego's Fa. Therefore, A(0,2) and B(1,3) would comprise a patrilineal unit, as would A(1,3) and B(0,2).

The Ndembu perhaps express this patrilineal principle in the symbolism of hunting, a sphere in which a father is responsible for training a son. Even if the son is not a hunter, a father may still give him a hunter's name. The data are inconclusive but bear further scrutiny, since Turner has drawn attention to the hunting cults as a principle which "balances matrilineal descent" (Turner 1966).

AFFINAL TERMINOLOGY

There are four basic affinal terms: *ng'oda* (Wi), *mfumu* (Hu), *ishaku* (in-law of own or alternate generation), and *muku* (in-law of adjacent generation). There are some alternative affinal terms which are probably formed by adding a suffix to the terms for Ego's kin (see Table 5). The direct exchange relationships

TABLE 5
In-law of Adjacent Generation (*muku*)

HuFa	= tatawesanu
	= tatawenu
HuMoBr	= same as HuFa
WiMo	= mawenu
WiFaSi	= same as WiMo

expressed in the terminology for a male Ego's kin are not found in the terminology for a spouse's kin. That is, Fa and MoBr, and Mo and FaSi are no longer contrasted as they are in the terms for own kin. Further, if the term *musonyi* expresses a direct exchange relationship, why are there separate terms for Wi (*ng'oda*) and for Hu (*mfumu*)? They probably can be explained as expressing a particular marriage relationship rather than a direct exchange alliance between social units. In the same sense, the term *ishaku* duplicates terms for cross-cousin (*musonyi*) and probably grandparent (*nkaka*) and grandchild (*mwiji-kulu*). *Ishaku*, the singular form of *mashaku*, probably expresses particular in-law relationships.

The relatively small number of affinal terms is another bit of evidence which supports our hypothesis that Ndembu kinship symbols express a principle of direct exchange and a marriage section system. Many specific affinal terms would, then, be unnecessary if affinal relationships were expressed in the terminology for Ego's kin. Similarly, the extremely low marriage payment may be evidence for affinal relationships, as well as for the fragility of the marriage tie and of particular political alliances, as Turner has proposed (p. 265; 1965).

CONCLUSIONS

It will be useful to make explicit two characteristics of the present analysis. First of all, it has been concerned with the cultural aspects of the Ndembu kinship system and not with social structure. Secondly, the analysis has not pre-

sented a model for a whole social system but only for one aspect of a social system, namely a kinship system.

The following interpretations have emerged from the study of systems of kinship symbols.

1) Filiation: Ndembu filiation is bilateral, as we have seen in their ideas about conception and birth, and about rights to residence.

2) Descent: Ndembu have an ideology of matrilineal descent which is expressed in many kinds of symbols. The relationship of descent from a matrilineal ancestress is the diagnostic feature which the Ndembu differentiate from the net of genealogical relations and use to define a kinship category. Persons who are included in such a category are co-members of a descent unit as well as consanguineals related by filiation. And, as we have seen, the Ndembu may possibly use descent from a patrilineal ascendant to define another descent category symbolized by hunting rituals.

There is certainly a question as to whether the word "corporate" applies to Ndembu descent units. They are not corporate in the sense in which Goody (1964) uses the term; that is, they are not conceived of as being property-holding units at all. Further, it is doubtful that the Ndembu ever conceive of descent units assembling or wanting to assemble. The only possible exception is the one lineage ritual described above.

We may ask whether Ndembu descent units are corporate in the sense that each is undifferentiated *vis-à-vis* other like units. They certainly are not so in the sense that Nuer or Tallensi descent units are. There is no ideology of segmentary opposition, or fission, or fusion, or national genealogy. The only possibility which we must consider is whether Ndembu symbols of descent can be said to differentiate a "We" and a "They," thus making Ndembu descent units conceptually corporate. There is clearly an opposition expressed between relationships among people who are members of a matrilineal descent unit and among people who are related by filiation only. (There may be, as well, a principle of patrilineal descent, which may be marked by hunting symbols.) Matrilineal units are given the names of their respective headmen (p. 105). That is, a village residence unit is a symbol of a matrilineal descent unit, and the descent unit is thus identified by the name of the village. We do not have any information about names for patrilineal units, if in fact such units are explicitly recognized. Ndembu descent units, in summary, are not corporate in the social structural use of the term, but they are corporate conceptually in Ndembu ideology.

3) Alliance: Alliance seems to be a useful concept in analyzing Ndembu thought, but not only for the reasons that Turner suggests. He is interested in "local-political manipulations of kinship" (Turner 1966; emphasis his). He is, therefore, justified in considering the transitory aspects of particular marriage and political relationships. But in the logical structure of Ndembu kinship categories, there seems to be a pattern of continuing affinal relationships of direct exchange between social segments which, following Lévi-Strauss, can be usefully called "alliance."

4) Consanguinity and affinity: The contrast between consanguinity and affinity appears in at least two different symbolic environments. This may be seen in the grandparent-grandchild relationship. In one domain the relationship is one of consanguinity, even co-membership in a matrilineal descent unit (e.g., MoMoBr and SiDaDa); in another, one of affinity.

Finally, the usefulness of a cultural-symbolic analysis should be noted. Because we have tried to deal with symbols of Ndembu kinship and their interrelations in their own terms and not in the terms of social structure, we have been able 1) to propose a simple model of double unilineal descent and four marriage sections to describe the system, 2) to raise further questions which may lead to the discovery of a principle of Ndembu kinship which Turner did not discover—namely, patrilineal descent, and 3) to put forth some possible solutions to the problems and contradictions which this type of analysis seemed to raise. One cannot consider all symbols of kinship on the same level and expect to find no contradictions. Rather, one must isolate a particular symbolic domain and then analyze the role played by a particular symbol or symbolic opposition in that domain.

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